

HOUSE BILL 1785

By Reeves

AN ACT to amend Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 49,
relative to interscholastic athletics.

BE IT ENACTED BY THE GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE:

SECTION 1. Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 49, Chapter 50, Part 8, is amended by
adding the following as a new section:

(a)

(1) If a public high school established under the jurisdiction of an LEA to
serve students in any of the grades nine through twelve (9-12) is a member of an
organization or an association that regulates interscholastic athletic competition,
then the LEA shall permit participation in interscholastic athletics offered at the
public high school by a high school student who:

(A) Is enrolled in a private school that:

(i) Serves fewer than two hundred (200) students; and

(ii) Is located within the geographic boundaries of the LEA;

(B) Satisfies the eligibility requirements established by the
organization or association; and

(C) Resides within the geographic boundaries of the LEA.

(2) A high school student who meets the requirements of subdivision
(a)(1) may only participate in interscholastic athletics at the public high school
that the student is zoned to attend.

(b) If a public high school established under the jurisdiction of an LEA offers its
students the opportunity to participate in interscholastic athletic competition at the public
high school without the school being a member of an organization or an association that

regulates interscholastic athletic competition, then the LEA shall permit participation in interscholastic athletics at the public high school by a high school student who is enrolled in a private school described in subdivision (a)(1)(A) and who is zoned to attend the public high school. This subsection (b) does not prevent or interfere with the application and enforcement of any eligibility requirements of an organization or association that regulates interscholastic athletic competition as set forth in subsection (a) if the public high school at which the student seeks to participate in interscholastic athletics pursuant to this section is a member of such an organization or association.

(c) This section does not guarantee that a high school student who is enrolled in a private school described in subdivision (a)(1)(A) and who is trying out for an interscholastic athletics team at a public high school will make the team or supplant the authority of any coaches or other school officials in deciding who makes the team. This section is only intended to guarantee that the private school student is not prohibited from trying out for an interscholastic athletics team at the public high school if the student is otherwise eligible to participate under the rules of the organization or association, solely by reason of the student's status as a private school student.

(d) This section does not limit or supplant the authority of any organization or association to determine eligibility and to establish, modify, and enforce its rules and eligibility requirements, including those applicable to private school students.

SECTION 2. This act takes effect July 1, 2026, the public welfare requiring it, and applies to the 2026-2027 school year and each school year thereafter.